

Remote Monitoring & Management (RMM) Tool Abuse – Hunting & Detection

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Overview:

Remote Monitoring and Management (RMM) tools are commonly used by IT administrators and Managed Service Providers (MSPs) for remote support, device management, automation, and software deployment.

Threat actors increasingly abuse legitimate RMM tools because they:

- Blend into normal administrative activity
- Provide persistent remote access
- Often bypass traditional malware detection
- Operate using legitimate signed binaries

Commonly abused RMM platforms include:

- AnyDesk
- TeamViewer
- ScreenConnect
- Splashtop
- RustDesk & etc

In Scope Log Source:

- Microsoft Defender XDR
- WindowsSecurityEvents

The first three hunts are based on app names, while the other three are behaviour-based use cases.

1. DefenderXDR - Unauthorized RMM Tool Execution Detected
2. DefenderXDR - RMM Tool Download from Browser or Script Interpreter
3. WindowsSecurityEvents – Usage of Remote Access Tool Detected
4. DefenderXDR – RMM Tool Spawned by Browser or Script Engine
5. DefenderXDR – External Remote Session Activity from User Workstation
6. DefenderXDR – Detects suspicious autorun persistence commonly used by unauthorized RMM installations

Use Case/Hunt No 1:

Use Case Name: DefenderXDR - Unauthorized RMM Tool Execution Detected

Use Case Description: Detects execution of known RMM tools from endpoints where their usage is not approved or expected. Adversaries frequently deploy legitimate RMM software after initial compromise to maintain persistence and remote access.

MITRE ATT&CK:

T1078 – Valid Accounts

T1219 – Remote Access Software

T1105 – Ingress Tool Transfer

Query:

```
let RMMTools = dynamic(["AnyDesk.exe", "TeamViewer.exe", "TeamViewer_Service.exe",
"ScreenConnect.ClientService.exe", "ScreenConnect.WindowsClient.exe",
"ConnectWiseControl.Client.exe", "rustdesk.exe", "RustDesk.exe", "SplashtopRemoteService.exe",
"SRManager.exe", "SRFeature.exe", "AteraAgent.exe", "AteraRC.exe", "RemotePC.exe",
"RemotePCService.exe", "LogMeIn.exe", "LogMeInSystray.exe", "LogMeInRescue.exe",
"GoToAssist.exe", "GoToResolve.exe", "Bomgar-scc.exe", "bomgar-rdp.exe",
"BeyondTrustRemoteSupport.exe", "DameWareMiniRemoteControl.exe", "DWRCC.exe",
"Ammyy_Admin.exe", "UltraViewer.exe", "UltraViewer_Service.exe", "VNCViewer.exe", "winvnc.exe",
"tvnserver.exe", "tvnviewer.exe", "TightVNCServer.exe", "TightVNCViewer.exe", "RealVNC.exe",
"vncserver.exe", "vncviewer.exe", "MeshAgent.exe", "MeshCentralAssistant.exe",
"KaseyaAgent.exe", "AgentMon.exe", "LabTechService.exe", "LTSvc.exe", "LTTray.exe",
"NinjaRMMAgent.exe", "NinjaRMM.exe", "NinjaRemote.exe", "NableAgent.exe",
"SolarWinds.TakeControl.Agent.exe", "TakeControlRDViewer.exe", "ISLLight.exe",
"ISLAlwaysOnMonitor.exe", "DWAgent.exe", "DWService.exe", "ZohoAssist.exe", "ZohoMeeting.exe",
"ManageEngineRemoteAccessPlus.exe", "RemoteUtilities.exe", "rutserv.exe", "rfusclient.exe",
"FixMe.IT.exe", "FixMeIT.Client.exe", "SimpleHelpRemoteSupport.exe", "SimpleHelpServer.exe",
"NetSupportManager.exe", "client32.exe", "Netop.exe", "NetSupport.exe", "pcAnywhere.exe",
"awhost32.exe", "awrem32.exe", "AeroAdmin.exe", "Supremo.exe", "SupremoService.exe",
"ShowMyPC.exe", "ScreenMeet.exe", "Govomeeting.exe", "ChromeRemoteDesktopHost.exe",
"remoting_host.exe", "QuickAssist.exe", "msra.exe", "RemoteAssist.exe", "Mikogo.exe",
"NoMachine.exe", "nxplayer.exe", "nxservice.exe", "Parsec.exe", "parsecd.exe", "Remcos.exe",
"Radmin.exe", "RadminVPN.exe", "RemoteManipulator.exe", "TermService.exe", "mRemoteNG.exe",
"ApacheGuacamole.exe", "WaykNow.exe", "WaykDen.exe", "ToDesk.exe", "SunloginClient.exe",
"SunloginService.exe", "HopToDesk.exe", "Getscreen.me.exe", "Syncro.Service.exe",
"PDQInventory.exe", "PDQDeploy.exe", "Action1.exe", "TacticalRMM.exe", "Pulseway.exe",
"PulsewayManager.exe", "teamviewer.exe", "anydesk.exe", "splashtop.exe", "screenconnect.clientservi
ce.exe", "connectwisecontrol.client.exe", "rustdesk.exe", "radmin.exe", "ultravnc.exe", "tightvnc.exe", "v
ncserver.exe", "bomgar.exe", "dameware.exe", "remotepc.exe", "remoteutilities.exe", "gotomypc.exe", "
logmein.exe", "zohoassist.exe", "ateraagent.exe", "ninjarmmagent.exe", "meshagent.exe", "dwagent.ex
e", "tacticalrmm.exe", "pcanywhere.exe", "nomachine.exe", "chromeRemoteDesktopHost.exe", "msra.e
xe", "quickassist.exe"]);
DeviceProcessEvents
| where FileName has_any (RMMTools)
| project-reorder TimeGenerated, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, FileName,
FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessFileName, SHA256
```

Rule Frequency: Every 5 minutes**Rule Period:** Last 15 minutes**Rule Threshold:** Greater than 0 events**Recommendations:**

- Validate whether tool usage is approved
- Isolate affected endpoint if unauthorized
- Review parent process and download source
- Investigate lateral movement activity

Use Case/Hunt No 2:

Use Case Name: DefenderXDR - RMM Tool Download from Browser or Script Interpreter

Use Case Description: Detects RMM tools downloaded and launched via browsers, PowerShell, or command-line utilities. This behavior is commonly observed during phishing or post-exploitation activity.

MITRE ATT&CK:

T1219 – Remote Access Software

T1059 – Command and Scripting Interpreter

T1566 – Phishing

Rule Query:

```
let RMMTools = dynamic(["AnyDesk.exe", "TeamViewer.exe", "TeamViewer_Service.exe",
"ScreenConnect.ClientService.exe", "ScreenConnect.WindowsClient.exe",
"ConnectWiseControl.Client.exe", "rustdesk.exe", "RustDesk.exe", "SplashtopRemoteService.exe",
"SRManager.exe", "SRFeature.exe", "AteraAgent.exe", "AteraRC.exe", "RemotePC.exe",
"RemotePCService.exe", "LogMeIn.exe", "LogMeInSystray.exe", "LogMeInRescue.exe",
"GoToAssist.exe", "GoToResolve.exe", "Bomgar-scc.exe", "bomgar-rdp.exe",
"BeyondTrustRemoteSupport.exe", "DameWareMiniRemoteControl.exe", "DWRCC.exe",
"Ammyy_Admin.exe", "UltraViewer.exe", "UltraViewer_Service.exe", "VNCViewer.exe", "winvnc.exe",
"tvnserver.exe", "tvnviewer.exe", "TightVNCServer.exe", "TightVNCViewer.exe", "RealVNC.exe",
"vncserver.exe", "vncviewer.exe", "MeshAgent.exe", "MeshCentralAssistant.exe",
"KaseyaAgent.exe", "AgentMon.exe", "LabTechService.exe", "LTSvc.exe", "LTTray.exe",
"NinjaRMMAgent.exe", "NinjaRMM.exe", "NinjaRemote.exe", "NableAgent.exe",
"SolarWinds.TakeControl.Agent.exe", "TakeControlRDViewer.exe", "ISLLight.exe",
"ISLAlwaysOnMonitor.exe", "DWAgent.exe", "DWService.exe", "ZohoAssist.exe", "ZohoMeeting.exe",
"ManageEngineRemoteAccessPlus.exe", "RemoteUtilities.exe", "rutserv.exe", "rfusclient.exe",
"FixMe.IT.exe", "FixMeIT.Client.exe", "SimpleHelpRemoteSupport.exe", "SimpleHelpServer.exe",
"NetSupportManager.exe", "client32.exe", "Netop.exe", "NetSupport.exe", "pcAnywhere.exe",
"awhost32.exe", "awrem32.exe", "AeroAdmin.exe", "Supremo.exe", "SupremoService.exe",
"ShowMyPC.exe", "ScreenMeet.exe", "Govomeeting.exe", "ChromeRemoteDesktopHost.exe",
"remoting_host.exe", "QuickAssist.exe", "msra.exe", "RemoteAssist.exe", "Mikogo.exe",
"NoMachine.exe", "nxplayer.exe", "nxservice.exe", "Parsec.exe", "parsecd.exe", "Remcos.exe",
"Radmin.exe", "RadminVPN.exe", "RemoteManipulator.exe", "TermService.exe", "mRemoteNG.exe",
"ApacheGuacamole.exe", "WaykNow.exe", "WaykDen.exe", "ToDesk.exe", "SunloginClient.exe",
"SunloginService.exe", "HopToDesk.exe", "Getscreen.me.exe", "Syncro.Service.exe",
"PDQInventory.exe", "PDQDeploy.exe", "Action1.exe", "TacticalRMM.exe", "Pulseway.exe",
"PulsewayManager.exe", "teamviewer.exe", "anydesk.exe", "splashtop.exe", "screenconnect.clientservi
```

```
ce.exe","connectwisecontrol.client.exe","rustdesk.exe","radmin.exe","ultravnc.exe","tightvnc.exe","vncserver.exe","bomgar.exe","dameware.exe","remotepc.exe","remoteutilities.exe","gotomypc.exe","logmein.exe","zohoassist.exe","ateraagent.exe","ninjarmmaget.exe","meshagent.exe","dwagent.exe","tacticalrmm.exe","pcanywhere.exe","nomachine.exe","chromeRemoteDesktopHost.exe","msra.exe","quickassist.exe"]]);
```

DeviceProcessEvents

| where ProcessCommandLine has_any (RMMTools)

| where InitiatingProcessFileName has_any

("powershell.exe","cmd.exe","wscript.exe","mshta.exe","chrome.exe","msedge.exe","firefox.exe")

| project-reorder TimeGenerated, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessFileName

Rule Frequency: Every 5 minutes

Rule Period: Last 30 minutes

Rule Threshold: Greater than 0 events

Recommendations:

- Review download source/domain
- Check if user-initiated installation
- Investigate related phishing emails or scripts
- Block unauthorized RMM binaries on EDR/AV Tools

Use Case/Hunt No 3:

Use Case Name: WindowsSecurityEvents – Usage of Remote Access Tool Detected

Use Case Description: Detects events when unauthorized usage of remote access tool.

MITRE ATT&CK:

T1566 – Remote Access Tool

Rule Query:

```
let RMMTools = dynamic(["AnyDesk.exe", "TeamViewer.exe", "TeamViewer_Service.exe",
"ScreenConnect.ClientService.exe", "ScreenConnect.WindowsClient.exe",
"ConnectWiseControl.Client.exe", "rustdesk.exe", "RustDesk.exe", "SplashtopRemoteService.exe",
"SRManager.exe", "SRFeature.exe", "AteraAgent.exe", "AteraRC.exe", "RemotePC.exe",
"RemotePCService.exe", "LogMeIn.exe", "LogMeInSystray.exe", "LogMeInRescue.exe",
"GoToAssist.exe", "GoToResolve.exe", "Bomgar-scc.exe", "bomgar-rdp.exe",
"BeyondTrustRemoteSupport.exe", "DameWareMiniRemoteControl.exe", "DWRCC.exe",
"Ammyy_Admin.exe", "UltraViewer.exe", "UltraViewer_Service.exe", "VNCViewer.exe", "winvnc.exe",
"tvnserver.exe", "tvnviewer.exe", "TightVNCServer.exe", "TightVNCViewer.exe", "RealVNC.exe",
"vncserver.exe", "vncviewer.exe", "MeshAgent.exe", "MeshCentralAssistant.exe",
"KaseyaAgent.exe", "AgentMon.exe", "LabTechService.exe", "LTSvc.exe", "LTTray.exe",
"NinjaRMMAgent.exe", "NinjaRMM.exe", "NinjaRemote.exe", "NableAgent.exe",
```

```
"SolarWinds.TakeControl.Agent.exe", "TakeControlRDViewer.exe", "ISLLight.exe",
"ISLAlwaysOnMonitor.exe", "DWAgent.exe", "DWService.exe", "ZohoAssist.exe", "ZohoMeeting.exe",
"ManageEngineRemoteAccessPlus.exe", "RemoteUtilities.exe", "rutserv.exe", "rfusclient.exe",
"FixMe.IT.exe", "FixMeIT.Client.exe", "SimpleHelpRemoteSupport.exe", "SimpleHelpServer.exe",
"NetSupportManager.exe", "client32.exe", "Netop.exe", "NetSupport.exe", "pcAnywhere.exe",
"awhost32.exe", "awrem32.exe", "AeroAdmin.exe", "Supremo.exe", "SupremoService.exe",
"ShowMyPC.exe", "ScreenMeet.exe", "Govomeeting.exe", "ChromeRemoteDesktopHost.exe",
"remoting_host.exe", "QuickAssist.exe", "msra.exe", "RemoteAssist.exe", "Mikogo.exe",
"NoMachine.exe", "nxplayer.exe", "nxservice.exe", "Parsec.exe", "parsecd.exe", "Remcos.exe",
"Radmin.exe", "RadminVPN.exe", "RemoteManipulator.exe", "TermService.exe", "mRemoteNG.exe",
"ApacheGuacamole.exe", "WaykNow.exe", "WaykDen.exe", "ToDesk.exe", "SunloginClient.exe",
"SunloginService.exe", "HopToDesk.exe", "Getscreen.me.exe", "Syncro.Service.exe",
"PDQInventory.exe", "PDQDeploy.exe", "Action1.exe", "TacticalRMM.exe", "Pulseway.exe",
"PulsewayManager.exe", "teamviewer.exe", "anydesk.exe", "splashtop.exe", "screenconnect.clientservi
ce.exe", "connectwisecontrol.client.exe", "rustdesk.exe", "radmin.exe", "ultravnc.exe", "tightvnc.exe", "v
ncserver.exe", "bomgar.exe", "dameware.exe", "remotepc.exe", "remoteutilities.exe", "gotomypc.exe", "
logmein.exe", "zohoassist.exe", "ateraagent.exe", "ninjarmmagent.exe", "meshagent.exe", "dwagent.ex
e", "tacticalrmm.exe", "pcanywhere.exe", "nomachine.exe", "chromeRemoteDesktopHost.exe", "msra.e
xe", "quickassist.exe"]]);
```

```
SecurityEvent
```

```
| where EventID == 4688
```

```
| where EventSourceName == "Microsoft-Windows-Security-Auditing"
```

```
| where Process has_any(RMMTools) or CommandLine has_any (RMMTools) or EventData has_any
(RMMTools)
```

```
| project-reorder TimeGenerated, Account, Activity, Process, CommandLine, EventData
```

Rule Frequency: Every 2 Hours

Rule Period: Last 2 Hours

Rule Threshold: Greater than 0 events

Recommendations:

- Validate Installation Source
- Investigate Parent Process Activity
- Restrict Unauthorized RMM Tools
- Monitor and Isolate Affected Endpoints

Use Case/Hunt No 4:

Use Case Name: DefenderXDR – RMM Tool Spawned by Browser or Script Engine

Use Case Description: Detects suspicious remote access software installation behaviour regardless of exact filename.

MITRE ATT&CK:

T1566 – Remote Access Tool

Rule Query:

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where InitiatingProcessFileName has_any ("powershell.exe","cmd.exe",
"wscrip.exe","cscrip.exe","mshta.exe", "chrome.exe", "msedge.exe", "firefox.exe")
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("silent","install", "remote","support","agent")
| project TimeGenerated, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine,
InitiatingProcessFileName
| project-reorder TimeGenerated, Account, Activity, Process, CommandLine, EventData
```

Rule Frequency: Every 2 Hours**Rule Period:** Last 2 Hours**Rule Threshold:** Greater than 0 events**Recommendations:**

- Validate Installation Source
- Investigate Parent Process Activity
- Restrict Unauthorized RMM Tools
- Monitor and Isolate Affected Endpoints

Use Case/Hunt No 5:

Use Case Name: DefenderXDR – Detects suspicious autorun persistence commonly used by unauthorized RMM installations.

Use Case Description: Detects suspicious autorun persistence commonly used by unauthorized RMM installations.

MITRE ATT&CK:

T1566 – Remote Access Tool

Rule Query:

```
DeviceRegistryEvents
| where RegistryKey has_any (@"\Run",@"\RunOnce")
| where RegistryValueData has_any ("AppData","Temp","ProgramData")
| project TimeGenerated, DeviceName, RegistryKey, RegistryValueName, RegistryValueData,
InitiatingProcessFileName
```

Rule Frequency: Every 2 Hours**Rule Period:** Last 2 Hours

Rule Threshold: Greater than 0 events

Recommendations:

- Clear the run registry
- Review parent process and download source
- Investigate lateral movement activity

Use Case/Hunt No 6:

Use Case Name: DefenderXDR – External Remote Session Activity from User Workstation

Use Case Description: Identifies excessive outbound remote-management-style connectivity.

MITRE ATT&CK:

T1566 – Remote Access Tool

Rule Query:

DeviceNetworkEvents

/ where RemotePort in (443, 5938, 7070, 8040)

/ summarize ConnectionCount = count(), RemoteIPs = make_set(RemoteIP) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessFileName, bin(TimeGenerated, 15m)

/ where ConnectionCount > 20

Rule Frequency: Every 2 Hours

Rule Period: Last 2 Hours

Rule Threshold: Greater than 0 events

Recommendations:

- Review remote IP, block IP if required
- Isolate affected endpoint if unauthorized
- Review parent process and download source
- Investigate lateral movement activity

Reference URL:

- <https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1219/>

-----End of Document-----